

JOINTS

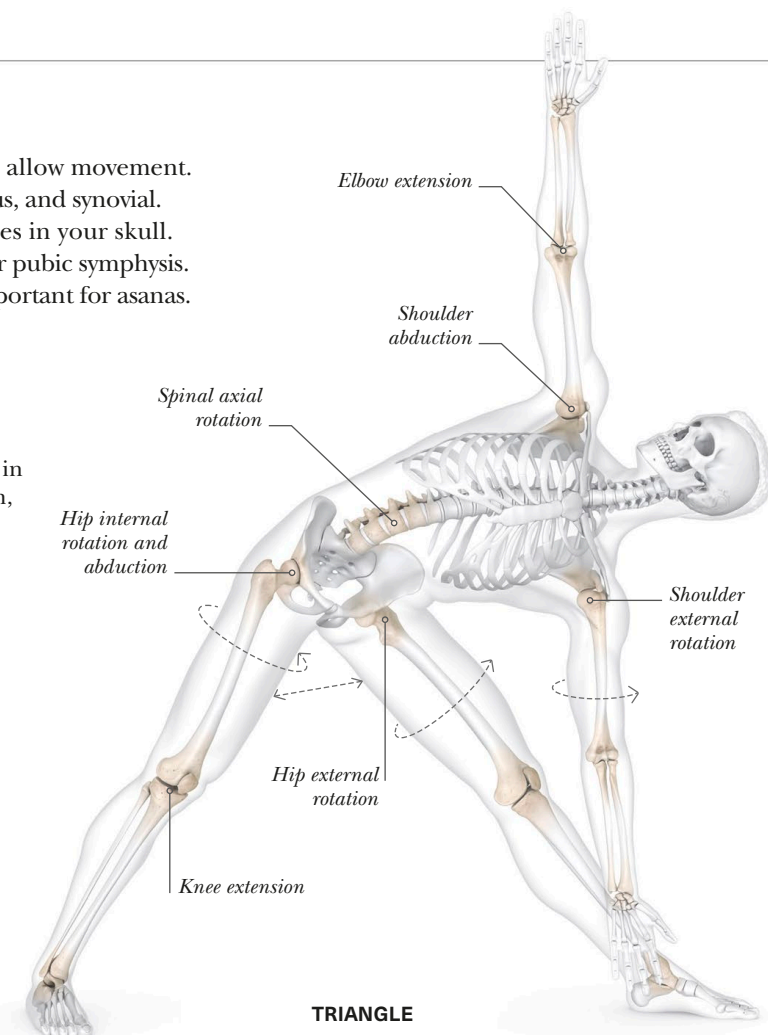
Joints are where bones unite and articulate to allow movement. There are three joint types: fibrous, cartilaginous, and synovial. Fibrous joints are immobile, such as the sutures in your skull. Cartilaginous joints are slightly mobile, like your pubic symphysis. Synovial joints are most mobile and are very important for asanas.

JOINT ACTIONS

Synovial joints of your body can move in many directions. Hinge joints in your elbow and knee mainly perform flexion and extension, like the hinge of a door. Larger ball and socket joints like in your shoulder and hip can also perform abduction, adduction, rotation, and circumduction, which is a combination of all of the above movements.

TYPES OF MOVEMENT

Flexion	Angle at joint generally gets smaller
Extension	Angle at joint generally gets larger
Abduction	A limb moves away from the body
Adduction	A limb moves closer toward the body
External rotation	A limb rotates outward
Internal rotation	A limb rotates inward
Axial rotation	The spine twists on its axis
Plantar flexion	Pointing the feet
Dorsiflexion	Flexing the feet



Inside a joint

Synovial fluid lubricates and cushions. It is a "non-Newtonian fluid," which means it gets more viscous or thicker in response to pressure, similar to solutions of cornstarch in water. With a sedentary lifestyle, synovial fluid may become thin and less effective. However, impact from the practice of yoga asanas causes synovial fluid to thicken, reducing pain and better protecting joint structures such as cartilage.

SYNOVIAL JOINT

Synovial joints allow movement while protecting bone ends from touching each other, which would cause damage. They are the most common type of joint in the body.

